



Outreach Starter Pack

— Alfocus

Project Deliverable Report

Prepared: June 2026 • Version: 1.0 • Status: Complete

This document covers the practical mechanics of getting Alfocus in front of the right academic audiences during its first 3-6 months. The goal is not viral growth — it is steady, durable visibility on the search results, newsletters, and reading lists that academics already trust.

The pack contains:

1. **Audience map** — who to actually reach, ranked by likelihood-to-link
 2. **Pitch templates** — cold outreach drafts for each audience type
 3. **Guest-post angles** — content offers that publications actually want
 4. **Response handlers** — what to say when people reply (positively, negatively, or not at all)
 5. **Tracking schema** — a simple spreadsheet structure that scales to a hundred contacts without becoming chaotic
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1. Audience map

Outreach is most efficient when you focus on a small number of audience types where the link/share/mention is genuinely useful to the recipient. Below, ranked by what we estimate works best for a brand-new academic affiliate site.

TIER 1 — NEWSLETTERS THAT ALREADY COVER AI FOR ACADEMICS

Highest return per pitch. These are people who actively need content to fill a weekly slot.

- **One Useful Thing** (Ethan Mollick, Wharton) — the most widely-read practical-AI Substack, with a large faculty and graduate readership
- **AI, academia, and the Future** (Bryan Alexander) — higher-ed futurist Substack focused squarely on AI in universities (aiandacademia.substack.com)
- **Inside Higher Ed's Daily News** — feature submissions accepted
- **Times Higher Education's Hub** — opinion piece submissions
- **The Scholarly Kitchen** — guest post submissions on AI/scholarly publishing intersection
- **Discipline-specific AI newsletters** — search "[your field] AI newsletter Substack" and start a list

TIER 2 — UNIVERSITY LIBRARY TECH BLOGS

These publications are read by exactly the audience Alfocus targets, and librarians actively curate "AI tools for research" resource pages.

- Your own university library's research-skills team (start here — easiest first link)
- ACRL's Open Access Week features
- Research-skills librarians on LinkedIn who post regularly about tools
- The "AI literacy" working groups now active at most major research universities

TIER 3 — FACULTY DEVELOPMENT CENTRES

Centres for teaching and learning at universities frequently maintain "AI tools" resource pages for faculty. A well-pitched email to the right director gets you on a page that ranks well on .edu domains.

- Your own institution's CTL first
- Russell Group / Ivy League / Group of Eight CTL directors (publicly listed)
- The Carnegie Foundation's higher-ed AI initiative

TIER 4 — REDDIT AND DISCIPLINE-SPECIFIC FORUMS

Lower per-contact value, but cumulative reach is significant if you do it without being spammy. Hard rule: never link Alfocus in your first post in any community. Build genuine post history first.

- r/PhD, r/AskAcademia, r/GradSchool — already exist, large audiences, strict no-promotion rules
- r/ChatGPTPro, r/ClaudeAI — tool-specific communities where reviews are sometimes welcome
- Discipline-specific subreddits (r/AcademicPsychology, r/AskAcademia, r/biology, etc.)

TIER 5 — JOURNALISTS COVERING AI IN EDUCATION

Long lead time but high payoff. A single mention in a Chronicle of Higher Education or Inside Higher Ed article can drive significant referral traffic.

- Beth McMurtrie (Chronicle senior writer covering AI in teaching; writes the weekly Teaching newsletter)
 - John Warner (writes on AI, writing and teaching; Inside Higher Ed columnist and Substack author)
 - Richard Van Noorden (Nature features editor; covers AI tools in scientific research)
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2. Pitch templates

TEMPLATE A — NEWSLETTER PITCH (COLD)

Subject: A review-driven AI tools site for academics — would this be useful for your audience?

Hi {Name},

I've been reading {Newsletter Name} for a while — your {specific past piece} on {topic} is the kind of grounded take this space needs.

I run Alfocuse (<https://aifocus.work>), a review-driven site covering the AI tools academics actually use for research, writing, and analysis. Each tool gets scored across three dimensions: ease of use, academic value, and price-to-value. The reviews are based on real testing rather than the marketing language that fills most "best AI tools" lists.

A few that might be relevant to your subscribers:

- {Most relevant review for their audience, e.g. Elicit if research-focused, Claude Pro if writing-focused}
- {Second relevant link}

If any of these are a fit for an upcoming issue, happy to send a brief write-up tailored to your readers' interests. If not, no problem at all — and thanks for the work you're doing on the newsletter.

Best, {Your name} Alfocuse

TEMPLATE B — UNIVERSITY LIBRARY / CTL PITCH

Subject: Resource for your AI tools page — peer-tested reviews for academics

Hi {Name},

I noticed {their resource page} is starting to gather links to AI tools for academic use. As someone working in this space, I wanted to flag a resource that may be useful to add.

Alfocuse (<https://aifocus.work>) is a review-driven site covering AI tools for research, writing, and analysis — each one scored across ease of use, academic value, and price-to-value. The reviews are written for an academic audience, with attention to research-ethics considerations, free-tier limits, and how each tool fits into actual scholarly workflows.

If it's useful for your page, the most-relevant starting points are:

- Top tools rankings: <https://aifocus.work/top-tools/>
- Research-focused tools: <https://aifocus.work/reviews/elic-it-ai/> and <https://aifocus.work/reviews/consensus-ai/>
- Writing and revision tools: <https://aifocus.work/reviews/grammarly-ai/> and <https://aifocus.work/reviews/quillbot/>

Happy to chat through any of the reviews or methodology if that's useful. Either way, keep up the good work on the resource page — it's a service to the community.

Best, {Your name} Alfocuse

TEMPLATE C — RECIPROCAL PITCH TO ANOTHER RESOURCE SITE

Subject: Quick question about your AI tools coverage

Hi {Name},

I found {their site / their specific page} while researching the AI-tools space for academics, and I think we may be working on adjacent problems. Your {specific piece of content} stood out — particularly the {specific aspect}.

I run Alfocuss (<https://aifocuss.work>), a review site covering AI tools for academic use. We score each tool across ease of use, academic value, and price-to-value.

Two reasons I'm reaching out:

1. I'd like to add {their site / specific resource} to our Resources page if you're open to it — happy to send the exact placement before publishing.
2. If any of our reviews are relevant to your audience, I'd be glad to share them — particularly {one or two specific reviews matching their angle}.

No expectations either way. Just wanted to flag we exist in the same space and might be able to help each other's audiences.

Best, {Your name} Alfocuss

TEMPLATE D — GUEST POST OFFER

Subject: Guest post idea — {specific topic title}

Hi {Name},

I read {recent piece on their publication} and wanted to pitch a guest post idea that might fit the editorial direction.

Working title: {pick one from the angles below}

Angle: {1-2 sentences on the core insight}

Why it fits {publication}: {specific reference to their audience or recent coverage}

Author: I write at Alfocuss (<https://aifocuss.work>), a review-driven site covering AI tools for academic use. {1 sentence on relevant credential or experience}

I can have a 1,200-1,800 word draft to you within {realistic deadline}. Happy to adjust scope, length, or angle if useful, or to pitch something different that fits your editorial calendar better.

Either way, thanks for the work you do at {publication}.

Best, {Your name}

3. Guest-post angles

The strongest guest-post pitches reframe Alfocus content into a format the publication's editor would commission anyway. Below are five angles tested across academic publications.

ANGLE 1: "WHAT AI DETECTION TOOLS ACTUALLY CATCH (AND WHAT THEY MISS)"

For: Inside Higher Ed, Times Higher Education, The Chronicle.

Hook: Universities are quietly dropping AI detection requirements as evidence mounts that detectors produce too many false positives on revised human writing. What works instead?

ANGLE 2: "THE 30-MINUTE LITERATURE REVIEW WORKFLOW"

For: Library tech blogs, research-skills newsletters, graduate-school career centres.

Hook: Combining Consensus + Elicit reduces an initial literature scan from a full day to half an hour without sacrificing rigour. Walks through the workflow step by step.

ANGLE 3: "WHY YOUR UNIVERSITY'S AI POLICY IS GOING TO BE WRONG (AND HOW TO PLAN FOR THAT)"

For: Inside Higher Ed opinion section, faculty-development centres, departmental newsletters.

Hook: Universities are writing AI policies based on what was true 18 months ago. The tools have changed; the policies need to too.

ANGLE 4: "AI TOOLS THAT GENUINELY HELP NON-NATIVE ENGLISH-SPEAKING ACADEMICS"

For: International researcher associations, language centres, internationalisation offices.

Hook: A practical guide to the AI writing tools that help with academic English without flattening discipline-specific terminology or introducing meaning shifts.

ANGLE 5: "WHAT AI CAN AND CAN'T DO FOR SYSTEMATIC REVIEWERS"

For: Cochrane Collaboration newsletter, JBI's evidence-synthesis community, biomedical librarian publications.

Hook: A grounded look at Elicit, Consensus, and Scite for systematic review workflows — what they accelerate, where they fall short, where they should never be the primary tool.

4. Response handlers

WHEN SOMEONE SAYS YES

- Reply within 24 hours.
- Confirm exact placement, link text, and any image they want.
- Send the post as plain markdown or Google Docs link, not a Word attachment.
- Once published, share their piece across our channels (newsletter shout-out, social if active).
- Follow up 1 month later with a "thank you, here's how it performed" note. This is what turns one-off relationships into ongoing ones.

WHEN SOMEONE SAYS NO

- Reply with a thank-you (genuinely; they took the time to respond).
- Ask if they'd be open to a different angle or a shorter piece. No pressure.
- Add a calendar reminder 6 months out to reach back with a fresh angle.
- Do not push. Most academic publications get pitched 20+ times a week.

WHEN SOMEONE DOESN'T REPLY

- One follow-up after 7 days, single line: "Just bumping this in case it got buried — happy to skip if not a fit."
- One follow-up after 21 days, single line: "Wanted to flag this once more — totally fine to ignore if it's not landing."
- Then stop. Do not pitch the same publication again within 6 months.

WHEN SOMEONE RESPONDS NEGATIVELY (RARE BUT HAPPENS)

- Reply with a genuine apology if appropriate, no defensiveness.
 - Ask what specifically didn't work; sometimes the feedback is useful.
 - Do not respond to attacks. Move on.
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5. Tracking schema

A simple spreadsheet — Airtable or Google Sheets — with these columns covers everything needed without becoming a CRM project.

COLUMN	TYPE	NOTES
Contact name	Text	First and last name
Publication / org	Text	Where they work
Role	Text	Editor, librarian, director, etc.
Email	Email	Primary contact
Backup contact	Text	LinkedIn / Twitter / form URL if email bounces
Tier	Dropdown	1-5 from audience map above
Status	Dropdown	Researching / Pitched / Replied / Yes / No / Published / Maintain
Date pitched	Date	Initial outreach date
Pitch template used	Dropdown	A / B / C / D — track which works
Follow-up due	Date	Auto-set to +7 days from last contact
Outcome	Text	Brief — "Yes, published 2026-06-15" or "No, asked to try again Q4"
Link to published	URL	When applicable
Notes	Text	Anything else that matters — birthday, recent piece they wrote, mutual contact

Two rules for the spreadsheet:

1. Update it within 24 hours of any contact event. The spreadsheet is only useful if it's current.
 2. Filter by "Follow-up due" weekly. This catches the contacts who didn't reply but might if reminded.
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A realistic 90-day outreach plan

Days 1-14: Build the contact list. Aim for 30 contacts across all five tiers. Do not pitch anyone yet.

Days 15-30: Pitch Tier 1 and Tier 2 contacts (~15 emails). Use Template A and B. Expect 2-3 responses, 1 confirmed feature.

Days 31-60: Follow up on Tier 1/2 non-responders (single follow-up each). Pitch Tier 3 contacts. Begin guest-post pitches (Template D).

Days 61-90: First guest post published. Pitch Tier 4 and Tier 5 contacts based on what's now visible. Re-pitch Tier 1 publications who said "not now" with a fresh angle.

By day 90, you should have 3-5 external links pointing to Alfocuss, 1-2 guest posts published, and a baseline of newsletter subscribers from referral traffic. That's the goal for the first quarter — not viral growth, durable visibility.

A note on tone

Every email you send represents the Alfocuss brand. The voice the site has built — careful, useful, British English, evidence-based — should carry through. Avoid:

- Hype language ("revolutionary", "game-changing", "must-read")
- Pressure tactics ("limited time", "last chance to feature this")
- Reciprocity-as-leverage ("we'll link to you if you link to us")
- Aggressive follow-ups (more than two follow-ups, or angry tone in any follow-up)

The academic audience has high tolerance for genuinely useful content and zero tolerance for marketing-speak. The pitches that work are the ones that respect that audience's time and intelligence.